Padshah, Sultan Nuruddin Jahangir, whose ‘power reigned supreme and unchallenged throughout the land. This news,’ added Banarsi Das, ‘came as a great relief and people heartily hailed the new King.’

The years of rebellion and uncertainty for Jahangir before he finally became Padshah at the age of thirty-six, after having once been the chosen prince, seemed to have taken their toll on the new emperor. Jahangir’s son, Khusrau, immediately went into open rebellion; his actions were entirely predictable and yet Jahangir crumbled. ‘What’s to be done?’ asked the Padshah piteously when he was given this news. ‘Should I set out on horseback, or should I send Khurram?’ After the trauma of his own battle for succession with Akbar, Jahangir could not countenance rebellion in his son. He decided to pursue his errant son himself, and in his autobiography, the Padshah would write that this was one of the greatest decisions he ever took in his life. So rapidly did he set off against Khusrau, wrote Jahangir, that he did not wait for an auspicious hour, forgot to take his daily dose of opium, and was only able to consume one spoonful of a delicious biryani he was given en route. When Jahangir eventually captured Khusrau, he was unforgiving with all those who had supported his son, indulging in extremes of cruelty. He had some of these supporters trampled by elephants, and some were suffocated to death by being sewn up inside donkeys’ skins. Others were lined up by the side of the road to Lahore and impaled, while a weeping Khusrau was placed on an elephant and made to witness the suffering of his wretched followers.

And yet, despite his own long rebellion and overt rejection of Akbar’s Hindustani vision, when Jahangir became Padshah he did, in fact, demonstrate that he was, in many ways, his father’s son. In an ostentatious display of his regard for justice, one of his first orders was to have a golden ‘chain of justice’ strung from Agra Fort to the near bank of the Yamuna so anyone looking for redress could ring the bells on the chain and summon the emperor. He forgave the amirs who had acted against him, and he also persisted with Akbar’s Rajput policy, finally overcoming the very last bastion of resistance to the Mughals—the Sisodiyas of Mewar—by allowing them concessions never before granted to the Rajput clans. Jahangir exempted the Sisodiya rulers from sending daughters in marriage to the Mughals and from attending the Mughal court.*

Despite a few displays of religious bravado such as the destruction of the temple at Kangra, Jahangir continued to show a remarkable eclecticism